



**Getting ready** for your baby's arrival is truly exciting. This is an ideal time to start listing and **buying** what your **baby may need**. While you can, of course, still shop after the birth, you'll need a **core supply of basic items** ready from the beginning.

# Preparing for your baby

## Prioritize what you need

When you begin to feel secure in your pregnancy, it's a good idea to decide which essentials you and your baby will need. Then buy the equipment gradually so that once your baby is born you can focus on him, rest, and recover.

There are several larger items you need to have ready for your baby, including a stroller, a bassinet, a crib, and a car seat. Purchasing these things is likely to require the most consideration. For this reason, allow yourself enough time to browse and research. You may want to test out car seats and stroller before you buy, so plan a shopping trip before you get uncomfortably big. If budget is a consideration, think about what you could accept from friends and family if they have expressed an offer to buy an item, or what you can get secondhand.

Newborn baby clothes are adorable and it's easy to be tempted to buy items now that may actually see very little wear; many first-time parents don't realize just how quickly newborns grow. Buy some essentials now and then assess your baby's needs as he grows so that baby clothes don't go to waste.

Other worthwhile purchases to buy now are diaper bags, a thermometer (see p.292), and simple washing equipment. Breast-feeding requires little aside from a good nursing bra, but if you are planning to bottle-feed, buy a basic set of bottles and nipples. Don't panic if you think you want to breast-feed, but aren't sure how successful it will be; you can easily buy bottle-feeding equipment after the birth.

## Longer-term purchases

Before you feel pressure to get a nursery ready, keep in mind that your baby will be best off in the same room as you for the first six months. And newborn babies don't need much in the way of toys for the first few weeks. Their new environment and time spent getting to know you and gazing at your face provide all the stimulation they need. If you would like to have a couple of play items on hand, look for age-appropriate toys. Babies love high-contrast patterns and looking at faces, so baby mirrors and soft books with black and white patterns or bright colors are all your little one will need at first.